

Her, Hers, Herself and Her Own: Deriving Reflexive Possessive Pronouns in English

Chigchi Bai, Inner Mongolia University of Finance and Economics

Manfu Duan, Inner Mongolia University

Dorno Dai, Inner Mongolia Arts University

Mar 23, 2026

Abstract

Using the examples of *her*, *hers*, *herself*, and *her own*, this paper examines the internal syntax and morphological properties of English pronouns through the lens of Distributed Morphology. The central argument is that *her own* acts as a complex reflexive possessive pronoun, serving as the functional equivalent of the non-existent form *herself's*. Specifically, the possessive pronoun *her* is not an inherent reflexive; rather, its reflexive character in specific contexts is derived from the presence of the reflexive pronoun *own* in the syntax, which may be absent or present at PF. With *own*, *her (own)* functions as a reflexive pronoun governed by Binding Condition A, thereby avoiding a Condition B violation. As regards the derivation of *her own*, formal features such as phi-features [phi], possession [poss], and reflexivity [ref] are distributed across multiple nodes in the syntax, which ultimately cluster as single words *her* and *own*. The non-existent form *self's* is blocked by *own* for economical reasons.

Keywords: reflexive possessive pronoun, binding, fusion, Distributed Morphology, English

1. Introduction

It has been claimed that English lacks reflexive possessive pronouns (Gelderen 2000; Buring 2005; Reuland 2007, 2011; Despić 2015) and that possessive pronouns such as *her* are lexically ambiguous between plain and reflexive pronouns (Chomsky 1981; Reinhart and Reuland 1993; Truswell 2014). Challenging these views, this paper proposes that reflexive possessive pronouns exist in the form of a two-word phrase consisting of a possessive pronoun and an unrelated lexical item *own*, as in (1), and that the “ambiguous” interpretation of a possessive pronoun is induced by the absence of *own* at PF, irrelevant to its lexical nature. Using the examples of *her*, *hers*, *herself*, and *her own*, this paper argues that English possessive pronouns including plain and reflexive possessives are structurally possessive DPs and are formed in a portmanteau fashion.

(1) English possessive pronouns

Dependent possessive	Independent possessive	Reflexive	Reflexive possessive
<i>my, our</i>	<i>mine, ours</i>	<i>myself, ourselves</i>	<i>my own, our own</i>
<i>your</i>	<i>yours</i>	<i>yourself, yourselves</i>	<i>your own</i>
<i>her, his, its, their</i>	<i>hers, his, its, theirs</i>	<i>herself, himself, itself, themselves</i>	<i>her own, his own, its own, their own</i>

The assertion that English lacks reflexive possessive pronouns is based on the incorrect premise that the ungrammatical *self's* is the only form required for such a role, alongside the misguided belief that the possessive *her* can be lexically reflexive, as will be clear in the following sections. Section 2 examines the syntactic properties of *her*, *herself*, and *her own*, and clarifies the local binding and reflexive properties of *her own* as a possessive anaphor, which is alternative to the non-existent *herself's*. Section 3 proposes that English pronouns and anaphors (*her*, *hers*, *herself*, and *her own*) are derived in a portmanteau fashion; their differences arise solely from which functional determiner heads such as possessive, reflexive, and personal D alongside a nominal complement N/NP are selected for spell-out following syntactic assembly. Section 4 shows that case puzzles (*himself* vs. *myself/yourself* and *himself* vs. *his damn self*) are caused by factors related to the paradigmatic (ir)regularity and/or historical status of the pronouns. Section 5 argues that syntactic binding as a condition of reflexivity does not target the entire reflexive element but the phi-features within its structure, and that reflexivity arises between specifiers of clauses and DPs. Section 6 demonstrates that the intertwining between the status of reflexivity as being dependent on phi-feature agreement and the obligatory-determiner property of English leads to the optionality of *own* in phrases such as *her (own) cat*.

2. *Her, Hers, Herself, and Her Own*

While the possessive *her* is locally bound by and coreferential with the local subject in (2a) and (2b), it is reflexive-marked in (2b) but not in (2a). This discrepancy is striking, as *her own self* in (2c) and *her younger self* (2d) signal the consistency between *her cat* and *herself* regarding their internal structure and their distribution; they are all possessive DPs and c-commanded by a local subject, a requisite condition for reflexivity under Government and Binding theory (Chomsky 1981, 1986).

- (2) a. *Heidi_i loves her_{i/j} cat.*
 b. *Heidi loves herself.*
 c. *Mama almost got her own self killed.* (COCA [1990, FIC])
 d. *My mother fleetingly saw her younger self.* (COCA [2019, SPOK])

According to Reinhart and Reuland's (1993) view that reflexivity arises between co-arguments, the subject, the verb, and the possessive pronoun *her* do not form reflexive predicates in (2a), (2c), and (2d) because the subject and *her* are not co-arguments of the verb. This undermines the structural and distributional consistency among the pronouns/anaphors, particularly regarding their internal makeup and their ability to occupy locally bound positions. On the other hand, studies such as Truswell (2014: 226) hold that *her* is lexically reflexive while lacking reflexive marking in (2a), causing an asymmetry between it and *herself*. However, regarding the possessive *her* as lexically reflexive leaves open the question as to why this asymmetry is sensitive to possession, or why so-called intrinsic reflexivity is restricted to possessive pronouns such as *her*. Therefore, the asymmetry problems triggered by the morphological poverty of *her* as a reflexive item, lacking reflexive marking, cannot be neatly explained by either the lexical approach (Truswell 2014) or the predication-based one (Reinhart and Reuland 1993).

This paper proposes a novel analysis to capture these problems, arguing that *her own*

functions as the equivalent of the theoretically expected, yet non-existent, reflexive possessive *herself's*. The apparent asymmetry between *her* and *herself* is thus a superficial phenomenon rather than a fundamental structural difference. Specifically, when *her* occurs alone and is locally bound, the constellation of *her* and a hidden *own* acts as an anaphor.¹ The form *her* itself is thus not reflexive, with reflexivity encoded by *own*. Its reflexive-like reading is due to the optionality of *own*. We thus obtain two distinct structures in (3b) and (3c) for (3a). This means that a structure such as (3d) is not available.

- (3) a. *Heidi_i loves her_{i/j} cat.*
 b. [_{CP} Heidi_i loves [_{DP} her_j [_{NP} cat]]]
 c. [_{CP} Heidi_i loves [_{DP} her_i [_{DP} *own*_i [_{NP} cat]]]]
 d. *[_{CP} Heidi_i loves [_{DP} her_i [_{NP} cat]]]

Consequently, (3a), when interpreted as reflexive, is subject to Condition A, not to Condition B. This is why such sentences induce a *prima facie* violation of Condition B.

Her own exhibits characteristics typical of both possessive and reflexive structures. Possession is its inherent property. *Own* is a reflexivizer (Spathas 2014), because with it, *her* must be bound by and coreferential with the local subject. In short, the hypothetical form *herself's* does not exist in the English inventory,² while its functional equivalent *her own* exists as a possessive anaphor. *Her own* itself is not listed in the lexicon; rather, it is a constellation of lexical items driven by a syntactic operation such as fusion (see Section 3).

The most notable characteristic of *hers* is that it cannot select an NP complement (4), a property shared by *herself*.

- (4) *Heidi loves her/*hers cat.*

This indicates that the complement slot of *her* is already occupied, which is why it is no longer open for an NP. Specifically, it is occupied by a minimal nominal (N) spelled out by *-s* in *hers*, as is the case with *herself*, where *self* spells out N. This *-s* finds its counterpart cross-linguistically, e.g., *-h* in Mongolian (5) (Bai et al. 2025).

- (5) *Ene muur tüün-ne-h.* [Mongolian]
 this cat she-GEN-h
 ‘This cat is hers.’

3. From Syntax to Morphology

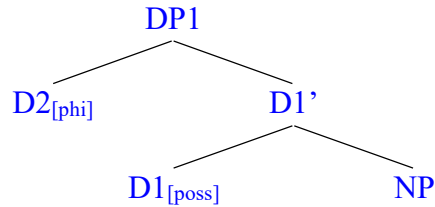
This section explicates the internal structure of *her*, *hers*, *herself* and *her own*. The core proposal is that they reflect the blurring of the head-phrase distinction in their derivation, where formal features enter the derivation separately and get clustered via fusion prior to vocabulary insertion (VI).

¹ See Burzio (1991: 100–101), Safir (1995: 570ff) and König and Vezzosi (2008) for further discussion of the anaphoric/reflexive properties of *own*.

² Siemund (2002: 3) reports that the genitive form of *self* occurred in the function of pre-modern English *own*, as in *æt his selfes ham* [Beo 1147] ‘at his own home.’ See also König and Vezzosi (2006) and Vezzosi (2006) for relevant discussion.

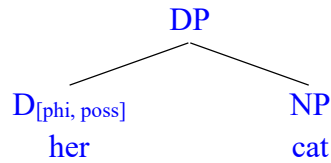
Following Davis (2023), possessive pronouns in English realize the fused outcome of a possessive determiner $D_{[poss]}$ and the material in its Spec. In terms of a *bare phrase structure* (Chomsky 1995a, 1995b), where non-projecting heads are equivalent to phrases, a bare determiner D2 occupies Spec of D1 (6).

(6) Initial structure of *her cat*



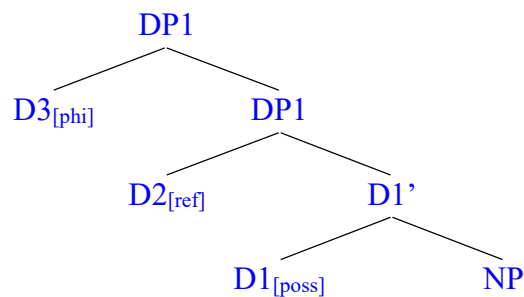
After (6) is built and before VI is applied, D2 and D1 undergo fusion, thereby creating a single node, with the features [phi] and [poss] clustered on it. Next, VI is applied; as a result, the morpheme *her* is inserted into the $D_{[phi, poss]}$, as in (7). Thus, two syntactic nodes end up as a complex head (a head with two features), with a particular morpheme assigned to it in a ‘portmanteau’ fashion.

(7) Ultimate structure of *her cat*



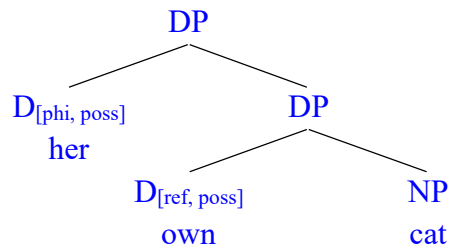
Based on this, this paper argues that the initial structure of anaphors maximally involves three distinct D heads, each encoded with one of phi-features [phi], a reflexive feature [ref] and a possessive feature [poss], as shown below. The complement of D1 is either a full nominal (NP) or a minimal one (N).

(8) Initial structure of *her own cat*



Both fusion and VI apply twice in (8). When they apply to $D2_{[ref]}$ and $D1_{[poss]}$, *her* is assigned to their fused outcome, i.e., $D_{[ref, poss]}$, as in (9), and when they apply to $D3_{[ref]}$ and $D1_{[poss]}$, *own* is assigned to their fused outcome, i.e., $D_{[ref, poss]}$. Importantly, after the application of fusion, the DP becomes a layered projection, containing two D heads. The higher D encodes personal possession, and the lower D encodes reflexive possession.

(9) Ultimate structure of *her own cat*



Note that the features [ref] and [poss] are bundled on the lower head D, which leads to the possessive reflexive property of *own*.

A few remarks are in order regarding the locality involved in fusion. Although fusion typically applies to adjacent nodes (Halle and Marantz 1993; Embick and Marantz 2008; Siddiqi 2006), D3 and D1 undergo this process throughout (8) and (9) despite lacking surface adjacency. Importantly, D2 does not qualify as an intervener because of its adjunct-like status. In terms of bare phrase structure, D2 and D3 are both non-labeling constituents. Since D3 does not select for D2 (or DP2), nor does D2 select for D1 (or DP1), unlike the case of T-v-V, they do not project their own phrases but rather act like adjuncts occupying a specifier position. Since adjuncts are derived in a separate dimension (Chomsky 2020), they do not compete for a head's operation, e.g., labeling. The same is true of fusion here, where D1, with [poss], is the head of the entire possessive structure. In a nutshell, the adjunct-like status of the D2 prevents it from blocking the fusion of D3 and D1. While the version of fusion defined in Halle and Marantz (1993: 116) and the one in Siddiqi (2006) (generalized fusion) require two terminal nodes to be sisters under a single category node to fuse, this requirement is not a property of fusion itself. Instead, it is a property related to a constraint on head-movement, which must take place before fusion is applied. Once head-movement takes place, heads naturally become sisters, to which fusion is applied. Since movement is irrelevant to the pronominal formation under discussion, the fusion of D heads (or their features) does not need to establish a sisterhood relationship.

An important question arises here as to why *own* instead of *self's* is chosen for [ref, poss]. We contend that one of two competitive lexical rules yielding the two forms wins the competition and picks out *own* on economical grounds. Specifically, why the grammar decides on *own* follows from either or both of the Elsewhere Principle (Anderson 1992: 132–135) and the Minimize Exponence (Siddiqi 2006: 14/82).

Assume that *own* and *self's* are both available from the possible lexical inventory for [ref, poss]. In accordance with lexical insertion rules such as Anderson's (1992) "subset rule", *own* rather than *self's* is inserted into the node because it matches the maximal set of the targeted features [ref] and [poss], whereas *self*, the stem of *self's*, matches a singleton feature set [ref], which is smaller than the set [ref, poss].

(10)a. The stem /self/ is only specified for [ref] and less specific.

b. The stem /oun/ is specified for both [ref] and [poss] and more specific.

In other words, *own*, being the form more specifically characterized for the target features, blocks the application of a more general rule that would yield *self's*, as predicted by the

Elsewhere Principle.

(11) Elsewhere Principle: Application of a more specific rule blocks that of a later more general one. (Anderson 1992: 132)

A more general rule adds *-s* to the stem *self*. However, computing the addition increases the processing load for the speaker. Thus, this rule fails given that there is already an irregular form *own* lexically specified for [ref, poss], which is generated by the more specific rule.

On the other hand, as predicted by a principle such as the Minimize Exponence, *own* prevails over *self's* since it has fewer morphemes than the latter, which has two.

(12) Minimize Exponence: The most economical derivation will be the one that maximally realizes all the formal features of the derivation with the fewest morphemes.
(Siddiqi 2006: 14/82)

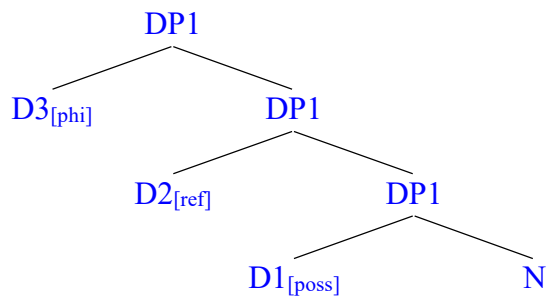
In short, the fused outcome is spelled out as *own*, which is not only more specific than the regular stem *self* with respect to the feature-form match, but also more compact than the clunky *self's* in terms of morpheme number. *Own* thus blocks *self's* on economical grounds. Historically, *self's* was used as a prenominal reflexive, (cf. fn. 2), but this use died out with the rise of *own* functioning as an intensive, reflexive possessive in the same period, i.e., Late Old English through Early Middle English (13).

(13) *He wolde ȝifenn all hiss aȝhenn sune hiss riche.*
(Ormulum (Burchfield transcript) l. 6899 (OED))
'He would give all his own son his kingdom.'

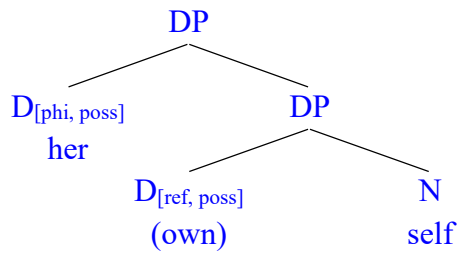
Additionally, since the nested genitive structure "A's B's C" (e.g., *his selfes ham* 'his own home') was "heavy" for speakers, it began to be replaced by the *of*-insertion structure "C of A's B" during the Middle English period (Allen 2008). However, where the notion of the reflexive possessive is concerned, the new structure (NP of *herself*) could not be used to express the meaning expressed by the former structure (*herself's* NP). To express the same meaning (the meaning of *self's*), the grammar chose to use *own* to fill the lexical gap caused by the loss of *self's*.

Herself is derived as follows. $D_{[poss]}$ and $D_{[phi]}$ undergo fusion, resulting in $D_{[phi, poss]}$, which is spelled out by *her*. The realization of $D_{[ref, poss]}$ is *own*, which, however, may or may not be present at PF. N is spelled out by *self*. *Herself* is thus analogous to body(part) anaphors in many other languages, where *self* can be construed as denoting a "possessum of the personal pronoun", as is the case with the body(part) noun in the anaphors.

(14) Initial structure of *herself*



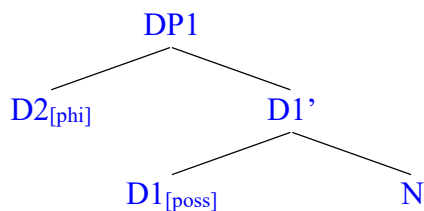
(15) Ultimate structure of *herself*



The status of *self* as N is indicated by the fact that *own* and even adjectives can appear between it and *her* (2c, d), as discussed by Ahn and Kalin (2018). Where *own* appears between *her* and *self*, it spells out D_[ref, poss].

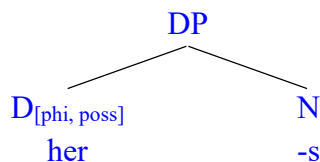
Hers has an initial structure as in (16). D1_[poss] and D2_[phi] are fused into a single node, which is assigned the morpheme *her* by VI, as in (17).

(16) Initial structure of *hers* (non-reflexive)



N is a full nominal and is therefore realized as a bound morpheme (suffix) rather than a lexical word.³ VI selects *-s* for it. Ultimately, *hers* is formed by affixing *-s* to *her*.

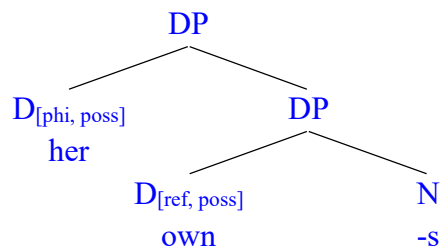
(17) Ultimate structure of *hers* (non-reflexive)



When D1_[ref] is present, the form *hers* is blocked. D_[ref, poss] is spelled out by *own*, which comes after *her*, which spells out D_[phi, poss], yielding *her own*.

³ The minimal nominal lacks maximal lexical content. This implies its status as a type of indefinite pronoun, following Baker's (2003: 95ff, 127ff) argument that nominals that have minimal lexical content and therefore don't have a substantive standard of identity/sameness are pronouns.

(18) Ultimate structure of *hers* (reflexive)



Combining *-s* with *her own*, *her owns* is available as an ultimate form in principle. However, as noted by a reviewer, *her owns* is completely unacceptable in the reviewer's idiolect; nevertheless, this variant and others such as *his owns*, *your owns*, and *their owns* are empirically attested, albeit infrequently, in COCA. The reason why *her owns* is unavailable (or at best less acceptable) is not structural. It seems to be related to the distribution of the *-s* morpheme, which is also absent in *mine* (vs. **mines*), as suggested by the reviewer.

Note that *-s* in *hers* is not a realization of [poss] but of N. However, *-s* in *his* and *John's*, for example, when used as arguments or predicatives, may be either the genitive marker or the realization of N. This means that haplology occurs in *his-s* and *John's-s*.

Also note that *hers* as well as *his*, *yours*, *ours*, *theirs*, and *mine* do not simply involve NP ellipsis. If it were derived by deleting the NP complement of a pronominal D head as in *This book is her ~~book~~*, as suggested by Postal (1966) and Elbourne (2001: 246, fn. 8), it would remain unclear how to explain the *-s* morphology added to *her*. Moreover, the nominal complement of the D head in *hers* in fact behaves like an indefinite pronoun (fn. 3), as is the case with *this one*, in which *one* is an indefinite pronoun. In either case, the deictic information is supplied by the realization of the D head, i.e., *her* and *this*. The NP ellipsis analysis would sever the structural link and semantic connectivity between *hers* and *this one* regarding their "D + indefinite pronoun" status. In contrast, the minimal nominal analysis correctly predicts the above-mentioned morphological and semantic properties of *hers*.

4. The case puzzle

Analyzing anaphors as possessive DPs explains other forms including *myself*, *ourselves*, *yourself*, *yourselves*, *itself*, *oneself*, and *one selves*, but it fails to predict *himself* and *themselves*, where accusative morphology surfaces instead of the expected genitive *hisself* or *theirselves*.⁴

⁴ In fact, many dialects allow *hisself* and *theirselves* (Edwards & Weltens 1984; Ahn and Kalin 2018).

(19) IPA phonetics for English pronouns

NOM	GEN	ACC
<i>he</i> (/hi:/)	<i>his</i> (/hɪz/)	<i>him</i> (/hɪm/)
<i>they</i> (/ðeɪ/)	<i>their</i> (/ðer/ or /ðeər/)	<i>them</i> (/ðem/)
<i>she</i> (/ʃi:/)	<i>her</i> (/hɜ:r/ or /hɜ:/)	<i>her</i> (/hɜ:r/ or /hɜ:/)
<i>you</i> (/ju:/)	<i>your</i> (/jɔ:r/ or /jɔ:/)	<i>you</i> (/ju:/)
<i>I</i> (/aɪ/)	<i>my</i> (/maɪ/)	<i>me</i> (/mi:/)
<i>we</i> (/wi:/)	<i>our</i> (/aʊər/ or /a:r/)	<i>us</i> (/ʌs/)
	<i>*hisself</i>	<i>himself</i>
	<i>*theirselves</i>	<i>themselves</i>
	<i>herself</i>	<i>herself</i>
	<i>yourself</i>	<i>*youself</i>
	<i>myself</i>	<i>*meself</i>
	<i>ourselves</i>	<i>*usself</i>

However, appearing in an accusative position, reflexive pronouns are theoretically expected to be all accusative-marked.

(20)a. *John hates himself*/**hisself*.

b. *I hate* **meself*/*myself*.

In light of this, the genitive forms are deviant while the accusative forms are normal. This said, there is a process of converting the case of reflexive pronouns from GEN to ACC (Ahn and Kalin 2018). Because genitive case, reflecting the internal organization of the reflexive pronoun, is “inner case”, while accusative case, reflecting its external syntactic configuration, is “outer case”, [poss] and [phi] are first bundled together before being associated with [case]. Converting GEN to ACC involves shifting from a simple feature set [phi, poss] to a complex one [[phi, poss], case]. This happens after the fusion of D heads but before VI (Ahn and Kalin 2018).

(21)[phi, poss] → [[phi, poss], case] (GEN to ACC conversion)

It must be noted that [poss] should not be a case feature, in the strict sense, but a feature of possession, whereas its morphological exponence being a genitive-marked pronoun. In this sense, [poss] and [case] do not lead to case doubling. There are not two distinct case features but only one (i.e., [case]) in the derivation. However, since [poss] is realized as case morphology, [poss] and [case] clash at PF. Thus, the resulting realization will contain only one of the genitive and accusative case markers. We contend that GEN, being the inner case, is satisfied first, blocking the realization of [case] as ACC, which is the outer case. This resembles Woolford’s (2006) “case hierarchy”, where inherent case overrides structural cases. Note that although the genitive seems to be structural within a possessive DP structure, it is more like inherent case with respect to the external syntactic configuration of the DP. Nevertheless, the accusative is assigned in *himself* and *themselves*, but not in other forms.

As regards why this is so, two possible factors, one being synchronic and the other historical, can be considered. From a synchronic perspective, the brain prioritizes paradigmatic

regularities over the “Inner blocks Outer” property, where the former serves as an “attractor” for the accusative-marking and the latter for the genitive-marking. Note that the third person singular pronouns (*he*, *him*, and *his*) share a common sound consisting of the consonant /h/ and the vowel /i/ or /ɪ/. Similarly, the third person plural pronouns (*they*, *them*, and *their*) share a common sound consisting of the consonant /ð/ and the vowel /e/. The portions /hi/ (or /hɪ/) and /ðe/ thus serve as the base for regularity. This is not true of other pronouns.

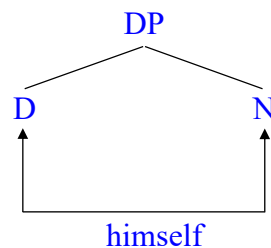
Itself and *oneself* are not self-evident regarding their case. One possibility is that they are the result of applying haplology to the corresponding genitive forms *its-self* and *one's-self*. That is, they are genitive forms, as is the case with *myself*, *yourself*, and *ourselves*. However, the possibility that they are accusative cannot be precluded based solely on their surface forms, as is the case with *herself*.

Importantly, regardless of how the reflexive pronouns vary in their case, they share a common underlying possessive DP structure. Their case variation does not have a direct impact on their internal structure. Treating the accusative reflexive pronouns as possessive DPs is supported by the fact that they are genitive-, not accusative-, marked, when not immediately followed by *self*.

(22) *himself* → *his own/damn self* (**him own/damn self*)
themselves → *their own/damn selves* (**them own/damn selves*) (Ahn and Kalin 2018)

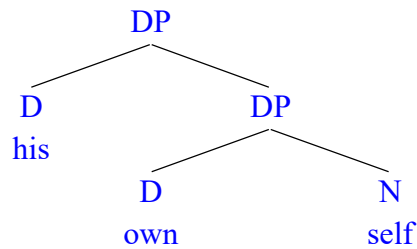
The case variation between *himself/themselves* and *his/their own/damn self/selves* has to do with the fact that a phono-morphological idiosyncrasy is observed with the former, not the latter. What would otherwise be a genitive form is now an accusative form (e.g., *hissself* vs. *himself*), leading to this idiosyncrasy. This allows us to assume that *himself* and *themselves* are shaped by a spanning-like process, which is preceded by fusion, as shown below.

(23) Ultimate structure of *himself*:



In this sense, *himself* and *themselves* are single units, where the pronoun and *self* are inseparable in the syntax. In contrast, the derivation of, for example, *his own self* does not involve a spanning-like process. There is a one-to-one correspondence between vocabulary items and syntactic nodes, where the D nodes represent the feature bundles that result from fusion, as noted in Section 3.

(24) Ultimate structure of *his own self*:



From a historical perspective, in Middle English, all reflexives were originally objective/dative (Gelderen 2000): *me self*, *thee self*, *him self*, *her self*. However, due to the morphological ambiguity of *herself*, the morpheme *self* transitioned from an adjective to a noun (Gelderen 2000: 64ff, 102ff), as speakers subconsciously reinterpreted *herself* as a possessive phrase roughly meaning “the self belonging to her”. However, while *hissself* and *theirselves* were also created during this period by speakers trying to follow the same analogy, they failed to become standard because of the early fusion that occurred in *him/them* and *self/selves*, which may be attributed to the “split” between third and first/second persons (Gelderen 2000: 132ff). Specifically, *him/them* and *self/selves* fused into a single unbreakable unit much earlier than the other forms (Gelderen 2000: 107, 119). Once a word is lexicalized, it is much harder for its internal grammar to change.

5. Binding

The classification of *own* as an anaphor has been controversial, as researchers have offered conflicting views on its relationship to binding principles. Below we examine two representative views.

Zribi-Hertz (1995) treats *own* as a morphological modifier of a pronoun such as *her* rather than an anaphor, arguing that its distribution is not governed by strict syntactic binding. However, if *own* were a modifier, it would remain unclear why the complex forms such as *herself* often do behave like locally bound reflexives (Higginbotham 1985: 576–577; Quirk et al. 1985: 363; Saxon 1991), as illustrated below.

(25)a. *Ellen_i believes that Heidi_j loves her_{i/j} cat.*

b. *Ellen_i believes that Heidi_j loves her_{*i/j} own cat.*

c. *Ellen_i believes that Heidi_j loves her_{*i/j}-self.*

For Zribi-Hertz (1995), *herself* is not an anaphor either and *self* is also a morphological modifier of *her*. However, her characterization of *own* and *self* as adjuncts to the pronoun is theoretically problematic given that right-adjunction is precluded under general structural constraints (Kayne 1994).

Unlike Zribi-Hertz (1995), Safir (2004) treats *own* as an anaphor because its interpretation is referentially dependent on a c-commanding antecedent within a local domain. Importantly, however, *own* does not always trigger a local binding interpretation (26).

(26) *Her own husband would never shop where she could see him.* (Safir 2004: 199)

For Safir (2004), *own* in (26), where there is not an overt c-commanding local antecedent, is licensed as an anaphor because he assumes that covert movement (of *her own husband* here) at LF brings *own* into a local licensing domain, referred to as “Domain D” (Safir 2004: 148). Safir’s (2004) covert movement approach, however, is problematic because, as Komen (2011) suggests, it adds unnecessary complexity to the grammar, which may conflict with Minimalist efficiency.

Anaphors lacking a c-commanding antecedent are typically classified as logophors (or exempt anaphors). Consequently, the use of *own* in (26) is identified as a logophoric occurrence. It should be noted that standard anaphors, such as *herself* in (27), can also exhibit this logophoric behavior.

(27) *John wondered whether that picture of herself had actually been burned by Mary.*
(Reuland 2011: 93)

All this said, *her own* and *herself* can be both locally bound anaphors, on the one hand, and both can be logophors, on the other hand. For Reinhart and Reuland (1993) as well as Chomsky (1981, 1995b), in a binding context, an entire complex anaphor is a bindee. This implies that *herself*, rather than *her* within it, undergoes phi-feature valuation under Reuland’s (2005, 2011, 2020) binding-as-Agree approach, as illustrated in (28). Put another way, *herself*, not *her* in it, participates in phi-feature Agreement with the binder *Heidi*. This is because *herself*, not *her*, is the internal argument of the predicate.

(28) *Ellen_i believes that Heidi_j loves [her-self]_{*i/j} cat.*

The possessor *her*, conversely, cannot be an argument of the predicate; consequently, Reinhart and Reuland exclude it from the category of reflexive pronouns, regardless of whether it appears in *herself*, *her own self*, or *her body* (29).

(29) *Heidi appreciates herself / her (own) self / her (own) body.*

This in turn would render *her* in *her own* non-reflexive even though *her own* is subject to reflexive binding within a local domain as is the case with *herself*. Given that *own* can assign a reflexive interpretation and locality requirements to personal pronouns such as *her*, a theory must be able to explain why this is so. Reinhart and Reuland’s (1993) approach fails to do so because it, incorrectly adhering to the co-argumental status of binders (antecedents) and bindees (anaphors), disregards the status of a possessive pronoun such as *her* as a bindee.

Following Bai (2026b), this paper demonstrates that it is not the complex anaphor itself but rather the personal pronoun within it that is the bindee because phi-features sit in the personal pronoun per se. This said, it is *her*, not *herself*, that agrees with *Heidi* as in (30). Importantly, this captures *herself*, *her body*, and *her own body* under a single generalization, providing a unified account (30b).

(30)a. *Heidi_i appreciates her_i-self / her_i (own) self / her_i (own) body.*
b. *Heidi_i ... [[her]_i-self/(own) body]*

It then follows that reflexivity arises between a local subject and the possessor in a possessive

DP structure. Binding, being the syntactic condition of reflexivity, thus targets the phi-features in a c-commanding position and that on a D head within the possessive DP.

(31)a. Reflexivity: Subject_i ... [DP possessor_i D possessum]

b. Binding: DP_[phi] ... [DP D_[phi, poss] ... [N/NP]]

Note that *self* as a minimal noun N and a lexical NP is irrelevant to binding. *Own* is the realization of the feature bundle [ref, poss] on D, and a possessive pronoun such as *her* realizes [phi, poss]. Interestingly, *own* can be absent at PF (29–30), allowing *her* to still refer back to *Heidi*.

6. Optionality of *own*

This section addresses the question of why *own* is optional in non-emphatic contexts such as (29–30). Three factors can be considered: two structural and one parametric. First, the possessive nature of anaphors, which are headed by a possessive D head, leads to the fact that, structurally, the feature [poss] is more prominent than [ref]. Therefore, the derivation chooses to make [poss] rather than [ref] visible at PF. Where [poss] is realized by the possessive pronoun *her*, [ref] may be left invisible.

The second factor is concerned with the derivational nature of reflexivity. Importantly, reflexivity is dependent on and conditioned by binding. Given that binding is phi-Agreement (Reuland 2005, 2011, 2020), [ref] is evoked by making phi-features agree. That is, reflexivity is only induced when phi-features on the binder and the bindee undergo valuation. Where phi-features do not undergo valuation, reflexivity does not arise. In short, [ref] is dependent on [phi], which overrides it. In reflexive binding contexts, the grammar prioritizes [phi] over [ref]. This ensures that where [ref] is realized, [phi] must also be realized, but not vice versa. For example, *own* is disallowed without a personal pronoun that can realize [poss].

(32) **Heidi likes the own cat (of her(s))*

One might suspect that this is not the case because other languages such as Chinese, Japanese, and Mongolian allow bare anaphors without personal pronouns. Specifically, Chinese *ziji-de* ‘self’s’, Japanese *zibun-no/zibun-zisin-no* ‘self’s’, and Mongolian *öör-in* ‘self’s’ do not demand the presence of a personal possessive pronoun. The difference between these languages and English is arguably parametric, not structural, which is the third factor affecting the obligatoriness of *her* and the optionality of *own* in *her own*. Specifically, a D head (D_[phi] here) must be overtly realized as a determiner because English, unlike the other three languages, is not a zero-determiner language. *Own*, the realization of D_[ref, poss], is not a determiner but rather a bare anaphor, where [phi] is lacking.

(33) **Heidi likes own cat (of her(s))*

Consequently, a determiner must be present for *own* and [phi] as well as [poss] rather than [ref] must be realized. This implies that any determiner that is present for *own* is inevitably a possessive personal pronoun.

7. Conclusion

This paper has demonstrated that English compound forms such as *her own* are reflexive possessive pronouns both functionally and structurally and are formed in a portmanteau fashion. The following specific proposals have been justified. First, possessive pronouns such as *her* are not lexically reflexive. The *prima facie* lexical ambiguity is in fact structural ambiguity. Second, structurally, anaphors are possessive DPs where a D head bearing a possessive feature selects a minimal nominal N as its complement. The specifier of this DP hosts bare D heads that encode phi-features and reflexivity. Third, the reflexive function of the reflexive pronoun is strictly dependent on binding conditions in the syntax, where binding targets phi-features in the compositional possessive structure of the “pronoun-*own*”. Reflexivity arises when the phi-features on that D head agree with and are valued by those on a c-commanding subject. It is thus not necessarily a relation between co-arguments but rather one between specifiers such as subjects and possessors (Bai 2026a). Fourth, where possessive DPs are concerned, it is not necessarily true that reflexivity must be reflexive-marked, contrary to Reinhart and Reuland (1993). This is why a possessive pronoun such as *her* can be used as a bound pronoun in reflexive contexts and why the reflexively used *own*, present in the syntax, can be absent at PF in English.

The proposed analysis offers a unified solution to several issues that earlier models, like Reinhart and Reuland’s (1993) predication-based approach, simply cannot handle. These issues include: 1) correctly interpreting the purported “ambiguity” of possessive pronouns such as *her*; 2) explaining the structural consistency between DPs such as *her cat*, *herself*, and *hers*; and 3) identifying how English-specific complex anaphors like *her own* function as possessive reflexives. Ultimately, this approach situates these forms within the broader cross-linguistic framework of how grammar encodes reflexivity and possession.

Acknowledgments: We thank the anonymous reviewers for their comments. All remaining errors, if any, are our own. This work is supported by National Social Science Fund of China [21XYY018].

References

- Ahn, Byron & Laura Kalin. 2018. What’s in a (English) reflexive. In Sherry Hucklebridge and Max Nelson (eds.). *Proceedings of the 48th Annual Meeting of the North East Linguistic Society*, 1–14. Amherst, MA: GLSA.
- Allen, Cynthia. 2008. *Genitives in Early English: Typology and Evidence*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Anderson, Stephen R. 1992. *A-Morphous Morphology*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press
- Bai, Chigchi. 2026a. What can Mongolian tell us about reflexives and reflexivity?. Available at: <https://ling.auf.net/lingbuzz/008696>.
- Bai, Chigchi. 2026b. What can Mongolian tell us about binding?. Available at: <https://ling.auf.net/lingbuzz/009651>.
- Bai, Chigchi, Dabhubayar Huang & Wuyunga. 2025. The morphosyntax of possessive

- pronouns, reflexives and silent nominal in Mongolian. *Proceedings of the 18th Workshop on Altaic Formal Linguistics (MIT Working Papers in Linguistics 97)*. 41–50.
- Baker, Mark C. 2003. *Lexical Categories: Verbs, Nouns, and Adjectives*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Büring, Daniel. 2005. *Binding Theory*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Burzio, Luigi. 1991. The morphological basis of anaphora. *Journal of Linguistics* 27. 81–105.
- Chomsky, Noam. 1981. *Lectures on Government and Binding*. Dordrecht: Foris.
- Chomsky, Noam. 1986. *Barriers*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Chomsky, Noam. 1995a. Bare phrase structure. In Gert Webelhuth (ed.). *Government and Binding Theory and the Minimalist Program* (Generative Syntax 1), 383–439. Cambridge, MA: Blackwell.
- Chomsky, Noam. 1995b. *The Minimalist Program*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2020. The UCLA lectures. Available at: <https://ling.auf.net/lingbuzz/005485>.
- Davis, Colin P. B. 2023. The unextractability of English possessive pronouns: On portmanteau formation and the syntax-morphology interface. Available at: <https://ling.auf.net/lingbuzz/006212>.
- Davies, Mark. 2008–. *The Corpus of Contemporary American English (COCA)*. Available from: www.english-corpora.org/coca/.
- Despić, Miloje. 2015. Phases, reflexives, and definiteness. *Syntax* 18. 201–234.
- Edwards, Viv K. & Bert Weltens. 1984. Research on Non-standard dialects of British English. In Wolfgang Viereck (ed.). *Focus on England and Wales*, 97–139. Amsterdam & Philadelphia: John Benjamins.
- Elbourne, Paul. 2001. E-type anaphora as NP-deletion. *Natural Language Semantics* 9. 241–288.
- Embick, David & Alec Marantz. 2008. Architecture and blocking. *Linguistic Inquiry* 39. 1–53.
- Gelderen, Elly van. 2000. *A History of English Reflexive Pronouns: Person, Self, and Interpretability*. Amsterdam & Philadelphia: John Benjamins.
- Halle, Moris & Alec Marantz. 1993. Distributed morphology and the pieces of inflection. In Ken Hale and Samuel J. Keyser, (eds.). *The View From Building 20*, 1–52. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Higginbotham, James. 1985. On Semantics. *Linguistic Inquiry* 16. 547–593.
- Huang, C.-T. James, Audrey Y.-H. Li & Yafei Li. 2009. *The Syntax of Chinese*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Kayne, Richard. 1994. *The Antisymmetry of Syntax*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Komen, Erwin R. 2011. Review of Kenneth Safir, *The Syntax of Anaphora* (2004). *SIL Electronic Book Reviews* 2011-002.
- König, Ekkehard & Letizia Vezzosi. 2006. On the historical development of attributive intensifiers. In Andrew J. Johnston, Ferdinand von Mengden & Stefan Thim (eds.). *Language and Text. Current Perspectives on English and Germanic Historical Linguistics and Philology*, 151–168. Heidelberg: Winter.
- König, Ekkehard & Letizia Vezzosi. 2008. Possessive adjectives as a source of intensifiers. In Elena Seoane, María J. López-Couso & Teresa Fanego (eds.). *Theoretical and Empirical Issues in Grammaticalization*, 183–206. Amsterdam & Philadelphia: John Benjamins.
- Oxford English Dictionary (OED)*, Oxford University Press. Available from: www.oed.com.

Accessed 6 March 2026.

- Postal, Paul M. 1966. On so-called “pronouns” in English. In Francis P. Dinneen (ed.). *Report of the Seventeenth Annual Round Table Meeting on Linguistics and Language Studies*, 177–206. Washington, DC: Georgetown University Press.
- Quirk, Randolph, Sidney Greenbaum, Geoffrey Leech & Jan Svartvik. 1985. *A Comprehensive Grammar of The English Language*. London: Longman.
- Reinhart, Tanya & Eric Reuland. 1993. Reflexivity. *Linguistic Inquiry* 24. 657–720.
- Reuland, Eric. 2005. Agreeing to bind. In Hans Broekhuis, Norbert Corver, Riny Huybregts, Ursula Kleinhenz & Jan Koster (eds.). *Organizing Grammar: Studies in Honor of Henk van Riemsdijk*, 505–513. Berlin: Mouton de Gruyter.
- Reuland, Eric. 2007. *Binding Conditions: How Can They Be Derived?* Lecture notes, St. Petersburg University, St. Petersburg, Russia, and Utrecht University, Utrecht, the Netherlands.
- Reuland, Eric. 2011. *Anaphora and Language Design*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Reuland, Eric. 2020. The roots of pronouns and valuation. Available from: https://dspace.library.uu.nl/bitstream/handle/1874/429559/The_roots_of_binding_and_valuation_prefin_clean_.pdf?sequence=1.
- Safir, Ken. 1995. Semantic atoms of anaphora. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 14. 545–589.
- Safir, Ken. 2004. *The Syntax of Anaphora*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Siddiqi, Daniel. 2006. *Minimize Exponence: Economy Effects on A Model of the Morphosyntactic Component of the Grammar*. Tucson: The University of Arizona PhD Dissertation.
- Siemund, Peter. 2002. Reflexive and intensive self-forms across varieties of English Reflexives and Reflexivity. *Zeitschrift für Anglistik und Amerikanistik* 50. 250–268.
- Spathas, Giorgos. 2014. Disentangling own: evidence from association with focus. *Proceedings of SALT* 24. 271–289.
- Truswell, Robert. 2014. Binding theory. In Andrew Carnie, Yosuke Sato & Daniel Siddiqi (eds.). *The Routledge Handbook of Syntax*, 214–238. New York: Routledge.
- Vezzosi, Letizia. 2006. From *agen* to *his own*. In Nikolaus Ritt, Herbert Schendl, Christiane Dalton-Puffer & Dieter Kastovsky (eds.). *Medieval English and Its Heritage. Structure, Meaning and Mechanisms of Change*, 147–164. Bern: Peter Lang.
- Woolford, Ellen. 2006. Lexical case, inherent case, and argument structure. *Linguistic Inquiry* 37. 111–130.
- Zribi-Hertz, Anne. 1995. Emphatic or reflexive? On the endophoric character of French *lui-même* and similar complex pronouns. *Journal of Linguistics* 31. 333–374.